

The news – a conversation lesson

Topic: The news

Level: SfL L2/SQA Higher/CEFR C1/C2

Time: 90 minutes

Aims:

- to develop vocabulary related to the news
- to give practice of retelling the main points of a news story
- to develop the ability to discuss news stories

Introduction

In this lesson, students will develop their vocabulary to talk about the news. They will also be given the opportunity to discuss the news with their classmates and retell a newsworthy story that is important to them.

Procedure

Stage 1 – What's in the News Today? (10 minutes)

- Write up and ask students the following questions: Do you feel up-to-date with the news? Do you watch it or read it? Why do you watch or read it? What stories have you heard in the news recently? Are these local or global news?
- Have a brief discussion about the top stories, either local or global.

Stage 2 – Vocabulary (20 mins)

- Elicit words related to the topic of news, e.g. *headlines, tabloid, broadsheet* etc.
- Hand out Worksheet 1 and set up students in pairs.
- Ask students to read the short text about news and discuss the meaning of the words in bold.
- Ask each pair to join another pair to compare definitions.
- Write the words on the board and invite students to give examples of the word in a sentence to correct and/or check full understanding.

Stage 3 – Discussion Questions (10 mins)

- Set students up in pairs.
- Write the following questions on the board and encourage students to discuss.
 - What is the main purpose of television news? To inform, entertain or influence?
 - Do you think people generally believe all news stories are true?
 - What are some of the differences between television news and the news in the newspapers?
 - What do you think makes a good news story? (e.g. celebrities and their cars, a general election, the discovery of a cure for a bad disease etc.)

Stage 4 – Retelling an important news story (20mins)

- Give students an example of a news story you will always remember.
- Give students a few minutes to think of their own story they remember and to note down a possible headline, when it happened, what happened, where they were and what they were doing when they heard about it.
- In groups of three or four, ask students to share their news stories.
- Have brief whole group feedback to elicit any particularly interesting stories.

Stage 6 – Discussion – Which stories are newsworthy? (30 mins)

- Elicit job of a TV news editor and pre-teach *newsworthy*.
- Hand out Worksheet 2.
- Set up students in groups of three or four.
- Ask students to discuss the news headlines and select six of these stories to include in the news broadcast. They should decide on the order they should be presented and give reasons for their choices.
- Whole class feedback – ask one student from each group to briefly present their choices, order and reasons.

Extension activity – Types of Media

- In pairs, students discuss and write lists identifying the advantages and disadvantages for each type of media e.g. tv, radio, internet, newspapers etc.
- If you have less time, allocate one type of media per group to discuss.
- BBC Learning English materials and the Grammar Challenge series have recently published several podcasts with a focus on the news, which could supplement this lesson.